

FLAME SHELL

Soft, sandy seabeds are always being stirred up by moving water, making life difficult for many animals. But certain mollusks like this flame shell anchor themselves to the sand with strong threads, binding the sand together in a tough mat. The mat allows other animals to settle and form reefs that teem with sea life.



SITTING PRETTY

The sunlight filtering down to the shallow seabed allows a lot of microscopic plankton to live in the water. This supports animals that can survive by sitting in one place on the seabed and simply filtering the water for food. They include mussels and other mollusks such as clams, flowerlike sea anemones, and worms that live in tubes and spread crowns of tentacles to gather food.

◀ PEACOCK WORM

The feathery tentacles of this tubeworm act like a sieve, straining the water for tiny drifting animals and other food.

WOW!

In some shallow seas, old ships have been deliberately sunk to form artificial reefs where fish and other marine animals can live.



▲ GALÁPAGOS SEA LION

An agile hunter, the Galápagos sea lion can dive 660 ft (200 m), foraging for fish as well as squid and crustaceans.

SEAL BANQUET

Seals and sea lions hunt in the sea, but must return to the surface to breathe. Shallow coastal seas are ideal for them, because they can easily dive down to the seabed to look for the rich variety of prey that lives there, then come back up for air. In deeper waters, seals and sea lions often cannot reach the bottom, and have to use a lot more energy hunting fast-moving fish and squid.

